

BHUSHAN KUMAR

30, ENTREPRENEUR
MANAGING DIRECTOR, T - S E R I E S
TURNOVER IN 1997 Rs 169 crore
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 350 crore

SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE



SUCCESS MANTRA

Be passionate about your work and always be personally available to your colleagues

turning POINT

Assassination of his father in 1997 when he was stepping out of a temple in Juhu

learning CURVE

"People study business management but I had to learn on the job."

RESOUNDING COMEBACK

What he drives is probably the best indication of what T-Series's Bhushan Kumar is. At 18, the Mithibai College student had a penchant for being in the driving seat of a flaming red Ferrari. Today, at 30, and in charge of a music and film production company worth Rs 4,000 crore, comfort scores over speed and Kumar now prefers to be chauffeur-driven in a three-month-old Bentley. Yet he never forgets where he came from, a two-bedroom house in a cramped Delhi locality, where his father owned a juice shop. Kumar's father, the late Gulshan Kumar, worked a loophole in the copyright law to his advantage, making relatively new voices do cover versions of hit songs. He then produced and sold these cassettes at rates lower than the leading music companies. But in 1997, Gulshan Kumar was assassinated in front of a temple in Juhu. Only 19 then, Kumar was suddenly thrown into the out-of-control music business with producers looking to weasel out of contracts they had signed with his father. Kumar

had to start from scratch and the music rights of Sanjay Leela Bhansali's musical saga *Hum Dil De Chuke Sanam* became his first big purchase.

He soon realised that it was time to try something new. The company was yet to explore pop music. He approached Sonu Nigam, who had previously recorded covers for his father, to sing for a pop album. The album was *Deewana* that went on to sell 18 lakh copies, a rare achievement for the industry. It was Kumar's foresight that made the company break new ground. When cassettes became defunct and music CDs remained expensive, T-Series priced them competitively between Rs 29 and 49. And now, when physical sales are a dying genre, the company is adapting to radio, Internet and mobile. In just a decade, Kumar has turned a company best known for its devotional albums into a film music major. "I'm learning everyday," he says. "I know I have an ear for music but with films, I'm still on rocky ground." Indeed. One of this year's biggest flops, *Karzzzz*, is proof of that.

by Jhilmil Motihar

IN JUST A DECADE,
KUMAR HAS TURNED
THE COMPANY, BEST

KNOWN FOR ITS
COVERS AND
DEVOTIONAL
ALBUMS, INTO A
PREMIER FILM
MUSIC COMPANY
AND ALSO A
GROWING NAME IN
FILM PRODUCTION.